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YIBBI JANSEN



Centre of attention: Yibbi Jansen of Odisha Warriors celebrates after scoring a goal during the Women's Hockey India League match between Delhi SG Pipers and Odisha Warriors in Ranchi. K. R. DEEPAK

THE DUTCH QUEEN CONQUERS RANCHI

Yibbi Jansen, FIH 2024 Player of the Year, has overcome challenges to win Olympic gold and **inspire future players** through her journey and standout performance in India's inaugural HIL-W.

Santadeep Dey
santadeep.dey@thehindu.co.in

Dreams come easily to children. Back in the early 2000s, fringe millennials thought it would be cool to grow up and search for Aladdin's magic lamp. But it wouldn't have taken them long to realise that, more often than not, wishes don't get fulfilled.

Even the sensational Yibbi Jansen faced resistance when she told her family she wanted to pursue the sport, despite coming from Dutch hockey royalty.

Her father, Ronald, had won back-to-back Olympic gold medals in Atlanta 1996 and Sydney 2000, after winning bronze in Seoul 1988 with

the Oranje. Ironically, it may have taken Yibbi longer to convince him than the national selectors.

Ronald wanted his daughter to take up football, like her two brothers. But she had made up her mind in 2012 while sitting beside the former goalkeeper in the stands of the Riverbank Arena in London,